FREE BOOK

Getting Ready for Puberty

A step-by-step guide to puberty for all bodies, with a timeline so the changes feel predictable.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic children and young people from about 9 years old, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

NCCA STAGE
Primary (5th and 6th class) · Junior Cycle

Easy read

Puberty is when your body grows up. It happens to everyone. It takes a few years. It is normal. You can ask for help.

How to use this resource

- Read this book **before** changes start, ideally from 8 to 9 years old. Knowing what comes next lowers worry.
- Read one page at a time. Stop when your child has had enough. Come back later.
- Read the whole book, not just the pages for your child's body. Everyone benefits from knowing about all bodies.
- Use the timeline page on the wall or fridge. Tick changes as they happen.
- Use the 'questions I have' page to collect questions. Answer them at a regular calm time.

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What is puberty?

Puberty is the time when a child's body changes into an adult body. It happens to every person. Chemicals called **hormones** send messages that start the changes. Puberty can start any time from about 8 to 14 years old. It takes a few years. Some people start early. Some start later. All of that is normal.



Puberty starts at different times for different people.



My body grows and changes.



My feelings can change too.



It is normal. It is okay.

Remember

You do not need to do anything for puberty to happen. Your body knows what to do. This book helps you know what to expect and what to do.

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The puberty timeline

The order of changes is usually like this. The ages are a guide only. Your body has its own timetable.

Before puberty (about 6 to 9 years)

Your body grows slowly. Hormones are getting ready.

Early signs (about 8 to 12 years)

A growth spurt starts. You may smell sweat. Hair may grow under the arms and between the legs. Breasts may start to grow in some bodies. Testicles and penis get bigger in other bodies.

Middle (about 11 to 14 years)

You grow taller fast. Skin may get oily and spotty. Voices get deeper in some bodies. Periods may start in some bodies. Erections and wet dreams may start in other bodies.

Later (about 14 to 17 years)

Growth slows down. Changes settle. Body hair, breasts or voice reach their adult size.

Throughout

Feelings can feel big and change quickly. Sleep, food and calm time help.

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Changes for all bodies

Change	What happens	What helps
Growth spurt	You grow taller fast. Feet and hands grow first. You may feel clumsy or have sore legs.	Good food, water and sleep. Tell an adult if growing pains are sore. Check your shoe size often.
Sweat and body smell	Sweat glands get active. Sweat smells different from childhood.	Shower or wash daily. Wear clean clothes. Use deodorant (see the hygiene cards).
Body hair	Hair grows under the arms and between the legs. It may grow on legs, arms and face too.	It is normal and you do not have to remove it. Removing hair is your choice.
Skin and spots	Skin gets oilier. Spots (acne) can appear on face, chest and back.	Wash your face gently twice a day. Do not squeeze spots. Ask the pharmacist or GP if spots are sore.
Feelings	Hormones can make feelings strong and change quickly. You may feel angry, sad or excited for no clear reason.	Rest, movement, a quiet space and a trusted person to talk to. Use your calm-down plan.
Growing interest in others	Some people start to feel interested in or attracted to others. Some do not. Both are okay.	Talk to a trusted adult about your feelings. See the other RSE & Me resources on friendships and relationships.

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Changes in bodies that have a vulva, vagina and womb

- **Breast buds.** Small, sometimes tender lumps grow under the nipples. This is often the first sign. Breasts grow over a few years. One may grow before the other.
- **Wider hips and body fat.** Hips get wider. This is normal.
- **Discharge.** A clear or white fluid may come from the vagina. It keeps the vagina clean. It is normal.
- **Periods.** About two years after breasts begin to grow, many people have their first period. Blood comes out of the vagina for about three to seven days. It is not a sign of injury. It is not dirty. It is your body working. It usually happens about every four weeks, but at first may be irregular.
- **What to do:** Keep a pad or period pants in your school bag. Use the period visual routine cards in this series.



A period is blood from the vagina. It is normal.



I carry a pad in my school bag, just in case.



I can tell a trusted adult if I need help.

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Changes in bodies that have a penis and testicles

- **Testicles and penis grow.** The testicles are often the first part to grow, and the penis follows. They may hang at different heights. This is normal.
- **Erections.** The penis sometimes gets hard and stands out from the body. It can happen for no reason, at any time, even at school. It is normal and goes away on its own. Thinking about something else, or doing something else, helps.
- **Wet dreams.** During sleep, a white sticky fluid called semen may come out of the penis. It is normal and not a wee. You did nothing wrong. Change the sheets or pyjamas and put them in the wash.
- **Voice.** The voice box grows. The voice may crack, then get deeper. It settles in time.
- **Face and body hair.** Hair may grow on the upper lip, chin and chest. Shaving is a choice. Use the shaving steps cards in this series.
- **Breast tissue.** Some bodies grow small tender lumps under the nipples. This is common and usually settles. Ask your GP if worried.



An erection is normal. It goes away.



A wet dream is normal. I wash the sheets.



Voices crack. Then they settle.

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Sensory tips for new routines

Puberty brings new things to feel, smell and do. Some can be hard for sensory systems. Try these and choose what works.



Deodorant

Try roll-on, stick or spray. Choose unscented if smells are hard. Try a patch test on your wrist first.

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Showering

Water temperature, noise and spray can be hard. Try a gentler head, a timer, a seat, or washing at the sink.

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Underwear and bras

Try seamless, tagless, soft cotton. Try sports bras or crop tops if wires or straps bother you.

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Pads and period pants

Try different brands and types. Soft cotton or unscented may feel better. Wear one at home to get used to it.

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Hair removal

It is a choice. Electric razors are quiet and gentle. Try one on your arm first.

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Calm routines

Keep a regular routine, a visual schedule and a calm-down space for big feelings.

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Questions I have

Write your questions here. You can draw them too. Show a trusted adult. There are no silly questions.

My questions

Question 1: _____

_____

Question 2: _____

_____

Question 3: _____

_____

Question 4: _____

_____

Question 5: _____

_____

My trusted adults I can ask

At home: _____

At school: _____

The GP or public health nurse: _____

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Notes for adults

- Start early. Autistic children often benefit from preparation before changes begin. Use the timeline as a visual schedule.
- Explain what is normal and what is not. Say clearly that body changes are not a problem to be fixed.
- Do not tie puberty to age alone. Use language such as 'usually' and 'some bodies'.
- Rehearse practical routines: how to put on a pad, how to wash after a wet dream, how to use deodorant. Practise at a calm time, before it is needed.
- Plan for school: a bag with spare underwear and pads, permission to leave class, and a trusted adult to go to. Agree this with the school.
- Expect emotional ups and downs. Pause demands, offer quiet time and a way to say 'I need a break'.
- Talk to your GP or public health nurse if you have any concerns, for example if changes start very early (before about 8) or have not started by about 14.

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strand **Myself**, strand unit *Growing and changing* (5th and 6th class): physical and emotional changes at puberty; taught within the RSE programme.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 **Relationships and Sexuality** and Strand 4 **Emotional Wellbeing**: understanding puberty and its physical and emotional effects.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: prepare early, use visual timelines and repeat key messages in a predictable routine.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

Your GP or public health nurse

For questions about puberty, periods, body changes or health checks.

Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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